Latin *famēs* ‘hunger’

Brent Vine

Latin *famēs* f. ‘hunger’ (Pl.+), an archaic member of the 5th declension (“*ē*-stems”), is etymologically obscure; nor is there a clear basis for its *ē*-inflection, beyond the assumption on the part of some scholars that the 5th declension continues PIE (*e*)h_1-stems. This paper seeks to remedy both of these issues by updating a theory of Corssen (1863: 216) according to which the word belongs to the PIE ‘gape’ root (as in Gk. χάσκω, Lat. *hiāre*, etc.). The tentative proposal here operates with the well-attested *$\hat{g}^h eh_2$-*u*- form of the root, specifically an amphikinetic *m*-stem *$\hat{g}^h éh_2$-u̯-*ōm* that can be supported by Germanic words for ‘palate, gums, etc.’ (< *‘gaping [cavity]’). A generalized zero grade based on the regular application of laryngeal metathesis would produce a paradigm *$\hat{g}^h uh_2$-*m*- ~ *$\hat{g}^h uh_2$-*ém*- (loc. sg.); and for a word with such a meaning, the locative could well have served as the pivotal form for further generalization. According to one proposed scenario, instr. sg. *$\hat{g}^h uh_2$-*ém*-*eh*$_1$ would produce, after laryngeal loss and vowel coloring, a hiatus form *$g^h u.ámē$ that would then have been resyllabified as *$g^h u̯.ámē$ (by “reverse of Lindeman’s Law”), whence Lat. **famē* ‘with gaping’ (i.e., ‘hungrily’) as the basis for 5th-declension *famēs* ‘hunger’. An alternative scenario operates with a thematized version of the *m*-stem and the Italic adverbial formant *-*ē*(*d*).

0. The Latin 5th declension (“*ē*-stems”) notoriously incorporates many serious problems, a topic too vast and fraught to take up here in detail.[1] Prominent among such problems, however, is a series of difficult 5th-declension nouns with poorly understood *ē*-stem background; and among these, *famēs* f. ‘hunger’ (Pl.+) has the distinction of being in addition etymologically obscure. The object of the present contribution will be to sketch, with all due reserve for such a *vexata quaestio*, a possible etymological solution, one of the features of which will be an explanation that accounts for the otherwise unmotivated *ē*-inflection of the word.

1. Existing etymological positions can be briefly surveyed. For Walde-Hofmann (*LEW* s.v. *famēs*), the etymology is “unsicher”; but the lemma tentatively (“V[iel]l[eicht] …”) favors connection with Latin *fat*- words referring to ‘exhaustion’ (*adfatim*/*affatim* ‘sufficiently’ < *‘to exhaustion’, *fatīgāre* ‘exhaust’, etc.), comparing OIr. *·deda* ‘dwindles’, ON *dásinn* ‘lazy, inactive’ and similar material; thus theoretically (in older notation) a preform **d*^{h}*əm*- > Lat. *fam*-, beside **d*^{h}*ə-t*- > Lat. *fat*-. Essentially the same formulation appears in Pokorny (*IEW* 239, s.v. 3. *dhē*-, *dhə*- ‘hinschwinden’, with query), though qualified with the comment “In allen Gliedern etwas zweifelhafte Verbindung.”

The treatment in Ernout-Meillet (*DELL* s.v. *famēs*) offers a series of three unpromising observations: First, nouns like *famēs* (to which the similar inflection of *plēbēs* f. ‘common people’ is compared) “sont … d’anciens noms radicaux.” But further, “Le radical *fam*- n’a aucun correspondant hors du latin,” and finally “Le rapport souvent supposé avec *fatim* est invraisemblable.”

1 For general orientation, one may consult, for example, Ernout 1953: 67–72, Leumann 1977: 444–447, Meiser 1998: 147–149, Gerschner 2002: 151–163, Vine 2017: 761–763, Weiss 2020: 272–274.

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Little progress emerges from de Vaan's more recent treatment (*EDLIL* s.v. *famēs*). With regard to the hypothetical connection with a PIE "**dʰəm-*" (or **dʰH-m-,* in updated notation) belonging with Lat. *fatīgāre* and similar *fat-* material (cf. above), de Vaan sensibly observes that "this comparison is too vague, both semantically and formally." He then goes on to suggest (echoing Ernout-Meillet) that "The formation of *fam-ē-* might point to a root **fam.*" But there is no such root, and so we arrive at the same dead end already indicated by Ernout-Meillet.

2. Before further discussion of the etymology, it will be convenient to provide some basic information about the 5th declension, with particular attention to the problem of the background of the *ē*-inflection.

It is generally agreed[2] that there are two "core" 5th-declension forms, namely *diēs* 'day' and *rēs* 'thing', and that these developed *ē*-stem inflection secondarily, as a result of regular phonological processes. Thus acc. sg. **d(i̯)i̯eu̯m* > (Lindeman form) **diu̯ēm* by Stang's Law[3] (> Class. Lat. *diem*, with regular vowel shortening), with the long-vowel outcome as in Ved. *dyā́m*, Gk. Ζῆν and (secondarily) Ζῆνα; Lat. **diu̯ēm* then served as the analogical basis for the new nom. sg. **diu̯ēs* (> Class. Lat. *diēs*) and ultimately the *ē*-inflection of the word. Similarly, acc. sg. **Hreh₁-i̯-m̥* (: Ved. *rayím* 'wealth') > **rēi̯-m̥* > **rēi̯em* > **rēm* (> Class. Lat. *rem*, with regular shortening), whence the new nom. sg. *rēs* (with similar developments leading to *ē*-stem forms for some of the other cases).[4]

For the remaining 5th-declension forms, there is little agreement; but in essence there are two basic approaches:

> (i) The 5th declension ("*ē*-stems") is at bottom a Latin problem, or at best an Italic one, since there is little, if any, Sabellic material interpretable as "*ē*-stems", and little evidence for PIE "*eh₁*-stems".[5]
>
> (ii) According to a different view of the matter, some 5th-declension forms do in fact go back to PIE *(e)h₁*-stems, with alleged support from Baltic *ē*-stems, among other material.[6]

Although I personally favor (i), this is a non-issue here: With regard to (ii), no basis for the *ē*-inflection of *famēs* itself has ever been presented, beyond the general claim about the 5th declension. Thus if an explicit basis for this inflection of *famēs* can be identified, that should be a welcome development.

For the sake of completeness, I mention other isolated types that will not be addressed here, first of all the *ē*-inflection background of some forms with clear or relatively clear etymology (such as *fidēs* 'faith, trust', *plēbēs* 'the common people'),[7] and the background of various 5th-

2 See most conveniently Weiss 2020: 273–274.

3 "Lindeman form" and "Stang's Law": Fortson 2010: 70, 72.

4 There is disagreement about points of detail, e.g., **di-* in the "Leiden School" version arises analogically from zero-grade **diu̯-* rather than from a Lindeman form **diu̯i̯eu̯m* (see *EDLIL* s.v. *diēs*). Further, Lat. *spēs* 'hope' is sometimes placed with *diēs* and *rēs*; but this is a more complex problem, see Nussbaum 2021.

5 For this perspective, see, e.g., Weiss 2020: 272, similarly Tikkanen 2011: 42–43, Fortson 2011: 209 ("there was no *ē*-declension in PIE"), Piwowarczyk 2017.

6 This is the view of the "Leiden School"; see, e.g., Beekes 2011: 199, following Pedersen 1926.

7 For *fidēs*: perhaps a hysterokinetic *i*-stem **bʰid-ḗi̯*[+ *-s*], derivationally related to the amphikinetic *i*-stem **bʰeid-ōi̯* in Gk. πειθώ 'persuasion' (Hamp 1999, see more recently Yates 2019 for the πειθώ type); for *plēbēs*, a popular account is that of Klingenschmitt (1992: 127), proposing a basis in a hysterokinetic *u*-stem **pl(e)h₁-dʰ-ḗu̯*[+ *-s*], cf. Gk. πληθύς 'crowd'. (On this approach, see most recently Nishimura 2021: 77.) Even if πληθύς was an inner-Greek creation (πλήθω 'be full' → πληθύς, like ἴσχω 'restrain' → ἰσχύς 'strength'; so Nussbaum 1998: 534), the Caland *ro*-stem in O. **plífriks** 'plebeius' (Adiego 2001) may still support the existence of a parallel *u*-stem.

declension subtypes (and related 3rd-declension material) such as nouns in -(*it*)*iēs* and -*iēs*/-*ia* (e.g., *aciēs* ‘edge’, *mollitiēs* ‘softness’; *māteriēs*/*māteria* ‘timber’),[8] and of (3rd-declension) *i*-stems with nom. sg. -*ēs* and abl. sg. -*ē* (e.g., *sordēs,* gen. *sordis* ‘filth’ but abl. *sordē*; *tābēs* ‘melting’, gen. *tābis* but abl. *tābē*).

3. I suggest that a plausible solution to the etymological problem posed by Lat. *famēs* can emerge by significantly updating an old theory that is now all but forgotten. The general idea seems to go back to Corssen (1863: 216), and involved a comparison with words meaning ‘gape’ (as in Gk. χάσκω and χαίνω). This proposal was explicitly rejected by Walde-Hofmann (“abzulehnen”) – quite properly, given a flaw in its original conception – and is no longer even mentioned by Ernout-Meillet (*DELL*) and de Vaan (*EDLIL*). The formal details of the root in question will be treated in more detail below; but for the present it is sufficient to note that it began with PIE **ĝʰ-*.

In rejecting this proposal, Walde-Hofmann provided two arguments against it. First, this approach is “lautlich unmöglich, da lat. *f* nicht aus **ĝʰ* außer vor *u* (*w*).” Secondly, “semantisch ist ‘Hunger’ nicht aus ‘Aufsperren des Rachens’ zu gewinnen.” Let us evaluate each of these in turn, in a preliminary way.

The phonological objection is broadly correct: The theory, as originally proposed by Corssen, is indeed phonologically impossible. There is, nevertheless, the possibility that a revised version of the theory might be acceptable, as long as it operates with a sequence **ĝʰu-* or **ĝʰu̯-*.

As for the semantic objection: This is in my view unfair and unreasonable. A metonymic development from ‘gape, gaping’ and ‘(gaping) cavity’ to ‘eat, devour’, wherein a mouth which consumes something is the gaping cavity, is an easy one: cf. (again from the ‘gape’ root in question) Gk. χάος ‘primordial Chaos’ (Hes. *Th.* 116) and ‘empty space, void’ (Aristoph.+), with its late Greek denominative χαόω ‘destroy’, certainly from an earlier sense *‘devour, swallow up’. Similarly (moving closer to *famēs*), one can point to connections between ‘cavity, (gaping) mouth’ and ‘hungry; hunger’; cf. Eng. *maw,* for which one can conveniently cite the following basic meanings:[9]

1. the mouth, throat, or gullet of an animal, especially a carnivorous mammal
2. the crop or craw of a fowl
3. the stomach, especially that of an animal
4. a cavernous opening that resembles the open jaws of an animal: the gaping maw of hell

and particularly relevant for present purposes:

5. the symbolic or theoretical center of a voracious hunger or appetite of any kind: the ravenous maw of Death

Hence English fixed phrases or clichés like *ravenous maw* (or *hungry maw*) and (often with reference to ‘hunger’) *gaping maw*.[10] It is even possible to find evidence for associations between ‘gape’ and ‘thirst(y)’, as in the following:

8 See Piwowarczyk 2016, with earlier references.

9 Drawn from dictionary.com s.v. “maw1”. https://www.dictionary.com/, March 26, 2024.

10 For the idea of connection between ‘(gaping) maw’ and ‘hunger’, compare also the obsolete English idiom (17th and 18th centuries) “have a maw (to)” = “have an appetite, inclination, or liking for something” (*Oxford English Dictionary,* March 2024, https://doi.org/10.1093/OED/8362481707, s. v. “maw †4”.). (Thanks to Michael Weiss for suggesting this comparison.)

The thirsty earth soaks up the rain,
And drinks, and gapes for drink again.[11]

Thus, despite Walde-Hofmann, a solution to the etymological problem posed by Lat. *famēs* based on the PIE 'gape' root need not be excluded on semantic grounds.

Such a solution should have the following ingredients:

(i) a formal basis in an existing *m*-stem or *m*-enlarged formation (since, as already seen, no appropriate *m*-final root or root form, such as a supposed *$*d^hH$-*m*-, has yet been identified);

(ii) a formal sequence that allows for the development of Latin initial *f*-, i.e., *$*\hat{g}^hu$- or *$*\hat{g}^h\underline{u}$-;

(iii) a morphological background that accounts for *ē*-inflection (as opposed to an unsupported PIE "h_1-stem" or "eh_1-stem");

(iv) a plausible semantic basis, e.g., 'with gaping (mouth)' ~ 'hungry' → 'hunger'.

4. We may now consider the formal details of the 'gape' root, as currently understood. Traditionally (as in *IEW* 418–419, 449–450), this was identified as a so-called "long-diphthong root", with very variable shape (thus, as in *IEW*, *$\hat{g}^h\bar{e}$-, *$\hat{g}^h\bar{e}i$-, *$\hat{g}^h\bar{e}u$-, *$\hat{g}^h\bar{o}(u)$-, *$\hat{g}^h$*əu*-). According to the best modern analyses (Lubotsky 2011: 107–109, Covini 2016), as typically for reevaluations of "long-diphthong roots", this is rather a laryngeal-final root *$\hat{g}^heh_2$-, with various enlargements. The relevant data can be briefly surveyed as follows:

(i) Plain *$\hat{g}^heh_2$- is not attested as such as a verbal base (as is often the case with such roots), but appears in some possible primary nominal forms, as in Gk. χήμη 'mussel; cavity', χηλός 'large chest', χηραμός 'hole, cleft', among others.

(ii) For *$\hat{g}^heh_2$-*i*-/*$\hat{g}^hh_2$-*i*-, note the following:
(iia) Lat. *hiāre* and *hietāre* 'gape, be wide open' (Pl.+), *hīscere* 'open the mouth' (Pl.+), *hiulcus* 'open-mouthed' (Pl.+), etc.;
(iib) BSl.: Li. *žióti*, OCS *zijati* 'open (one's mouth)'; Pr.-Sl. **zěvŭ* 'muzzle' (CSl. *zěvŭ,* SCr. *zȉjev*);
(iic) TB *kāy*- 'open (the mouth)' (pret. ptcple. *kakāyau*); TB *koyn*, TA *koy*- 'mouth';
(iid) Perhaps Ved. *jéhamāna*- 'panting, gasping' (Lubotsky 2012);
(iie) Also a nasal present, as in Hitt. *kīnu-$^{-zi}$/kinu-$^{-zi}$/ginu-$^{-zi}$* 'open (up), break open', Pr.Sl. **zinǫti* (OCS *zinǫti,* SCr. *zȉnuti* 'open [one's mouth]', etc.), and Germanic forms, e.g., ON *gina* 'gape, yawn', OE *gīnan* 'id.' (> Eng. *yawn*), etc.;
(iif) Perhaps Lat. *gingīva* 'gum(s)' (Vine 2016a).

(iii) For *$\hat{g}^heh_2$-*u*-/*$\hat{g}^hh_2$-*u*-:
(iiia) Gk. χάος (§ 3 above), i.e., *χάϝος; for the digamma cf. χαῦνος 'empty, porous' (Pi.+);
(iiib) Gmc./Ba. words for 'palate etc.': OE *gōma* 'palate; pl. jaws' > Eng. *gum*, NHG *Gaumen* 'roof of the mouth, palate', etc. (more on this material below, in the next section);
(iiic) perhaps Lat. *faucēs* 'throat' (Winter 1982: 183).

(iv) *$\hat{g}^hh_2$(*e*)*n*-, as in the following:
(iva) Gk. χάσκω, χαίνω 'gape, yawn' (aor. χανεῖν, perf. κέχηνα), cf. § 3 above;
(ivb) Pr.-Gmc. **gana*- (ON *gan* n. 'yawning', cf. *gana* 'be opened [of eyes, mouth], stare').

The *u*-extended material in (iiib) will be particularly important for what follows.

5. We must now consider in more detail the Germanic and Baltic words for 'palate' and related concepts (§ 4 (iiib) above), since these forms provide the first "solution ingredient" identified above (§ 3 (i)), i.e., support for a formation in *-*m*-:

11 From *Anacreon*, II. *Drinking* (Abraham Cowley, 1618–1667.)

(i) for Germanic (filling out slightly the material cited above): OHG *goumo, guomo*, *giumo, gommo* (NHG *Gaumen*) ‘roof of the mouth, palate’, in part also ‘throat’, ON *gómr* ‘palate; gums’, Far. *gómi* and *gómur* ‘palate; oral cavity’, OE *gōma* (> Eng. *gum*(*s*)) ‘palate’, pl. ‘jaws’ (all masc.);[12]

(ii) for Baltic (but with velar for expected palatal): Li. *gomurỹs* m., *gomurẽ*/*gomerẽ* f. ‘palate; throat, gullet’, Latv. *gãmurs* ‘larynx, windpipe’.[13]

There is widespread agreement that these words derive ultimately from PIE *$\hat{g}^{h}eh_2$- ‘gape, be wide open’ (i.e., *‘gaping’ > ‘gaping (cavity)’, further concretized as ‘palate, throat, etc.’), with the Germanic forms based (at least in part) on the *u*-extended version *$\hat{g}^{h}eh_2$-*u*- (§ 4 [iii]).[14] The Baltic material, with apparent *u*-less *$\hat{g}^{h}eh_2m$-, is less directly relevant here, and will be left aside.

For OHG *goumo* and the other Germanic *m*-forms cited above: The complex variation in root vocalism is in some respects poorly understood; see in detail Bjorvand and Lindeman 2000: 311–312, Kroonen 2011: 303–304, and Neri 2016: 11. But the suffix morphology is tolerably clear (see especially Kroonen, as just cited), involving a background in PIE *men*- or *mon*-stems. This morphology itself is not directly useful for *famēs*: Strong forms *$\hat{g}^{h}\acute{e}h_2$-*u*-$m\underline{n}$ (proterokinetic) and *$\hat{g}^{h}\acute{e}h_2$-*u*-*mōn* (amphikinetic) would produce Lat. ˣ*haumen*, ˣ*haumō*, respectively, while the weak stem *$\hat{g}^{h}h_2$-*u*-m^{o} (e.g., instr. sg. *$\hat{g}^{h}h_2$-*u*-*mn*-*éh*$_1$) would yield *$\hat{g}^{h}uh_2$-m^{o} (by regular laryngeal metathesis), whence Lat. ˣ*fūm*^{o}. However, the Germanic *men*-stem or *mon*-stem material can in principle be based on an earlier (ablauting) *m*-stem;[15] cf., for example, PIE ‘earth’ (Hitt. *tēkan,* TA *tkaṃ*, etc.) and some of its derivatives,[16] including the well-established amphikinetic *m*-stem as in nom. *$d^{h}\acute{e}\hat{g}^{h}$-*ōm*, obl. *$d^{h}\hat{g}^{h}$-*m*-*ʹ*, loc. *$d^{h}\hat{g}^{h}$-*ém*(-*i*), as well as the *en*-loc. *$d^{h}\hat{g}^{h}$-*m*-*én* ‘on the earth’ (Ved. -*jman*), whence *$d^{h}\hat{g}^{h}$*émon*- ‘on/of-earth [animate being]’ (Gmc. **guman*-, Lat. *homō*, Li. *žmuõ*, etc. ‘person’). For the standard *m*-stem analysis of ‘winter’ (*$\hat{g}^{h}\acute{e}\underline{i}$-*om*-), see *NIL* 162–169, as well as Friedman 2003. To be sure, Steer (2013) has argued against the *m*-stem analysis of ‘earth’ and ‘winter’, in favor of analysis as root nouns. But the *m*-stem interpretations of these words continue to be vigorously defended,[17] and indeed the ranks of PIE *m*-stems are growing – see especially Pinault 2017 on *$h_2\acute{e}h_1$-*om*- ‘heat’ (underlying Hom. ἦμαρ, Arm. *awr* ‘day’, TB *emalle*, TA *omäl* ‘hot’), with notes (2017: 655–656) on *$s\acute{e}h_2$-*om*- ‘song’ (cf. Hitt. *išhamāi*- ‘song’, Ved. *sā́man*- ‘melody’) and *$h_2\acute{e}\underline{i}$-*om*- ‘resemblance, likeness’ (cf. Lat. *aemulus* ‘rival’, *imāgō* ‘copy, picture’, Hitt. *himma*- ‘imitation, substitute’, Ved. *yamá*- ‘twin’), as well as Pinault 2018: 294–295 on **dék̂-om* ‘group of tens, ten decads’ (cf. Ved. *śám* ‘[span of] 100 [years]’). These considerations therefore support the possibility of an original amphikinetic *$\hat{g}^{h}\acute{e}h_2\underline{u}$-*ōm* (with a meaning such as abstract ‘gaping’), with the following paradigm: nom. *$\hat{g}^{h}\acute{e}h_2\underline{u}$-*ōm*, obl. *$\hat{g}^{h}h_2$-*u*-*m*-*és*, -*éi,* -*éh*$_1$ → *$\hat{g}^{h}uh_2$-*m*-*és*, -*éi*, -*éh*$_1$ (with regular laryngeal metathesis), loc. *$\hat{g}^{h}uh_2$ -*ém*(-*i*).

12 For a more complete listing of Germanic forms, see Kroonen 2011: 302.

13 Thanks to Aurelijus Vijūnas for helpful comments on some of the Germanic and Baltic material.

14 So e.g., *IEW* 449 (s.v. *$\hat{g}^{h}$ēu*- ‘gähnen, Klaffen’), Krahe 1969: 128, Winter 1982: 183, Bjorvand and Lindeman 2000: 311–312 (s.v. *gomme*), Kluge and Seebold 2002: 334 (s.v. *Gaumen*), Lloyd and Lühr 2009: 563 (s.v. *goumo*), Watkins 2011: 32 (s.v. *ghēu*-), Kroonen 2011: 302–304, *EDP-G* s.v. **gōman*-/**gauman*-. Fraenkel (*LitEW* 161, s.v. *gomurỹs*) hesitates, because of the velar/palatal mismatch, and Derksen (*EDBIL* s.v. *gomurys*) inclines toward substratum origin in view of the absence of *u* (before -*m*-) as compared with Germanic.

15 So, in fact Bjorvand and Lindeman, as just cited, and *in nuce* Winter 1982: 183.

16 See in detail *NIL* 86–99.

17 Among much that could be cited, e.g., Kloekhorst 2014: 51 on ‘earth’ as *m*-stem and Pinault 2014: 199–200 on ‘winter’ as *m*-stem. Explicitly *contra* Steer on ‘earth’: Kloekhorst 2014: 51 n. 28, Pinault 2018: 295 n. 25.

To pursue this theory, we may make two further formal assumptions, both with good parallels in the 'earth' material: First, the zero-grade root could have been generalized at an early stage; and second, the loc. sg. could have served as a pivotal form. Thus for the first of these: With early generalization of the (metathesized) zero grade, we would arrive at a paradigm nom. *$\hat{g}^{h}$*úh$_2$-ōm*, obl. *$\hat{g}^{h}$*uh$_2$-m-és*, *-éi, -éh$_1$*, loc. *$\hat{g}^{h}$*uh$_2$ém*(*i*). This then provides "solution ingredient (ii)" (§ 3 above), i.e., a sequence *$\hat{g}^{h}$*u-*, which allows in principle for Latin *f-* as a phonologically regular outcome.

6. The above considerations lead, in turn, to two different scenarios that could underlie Lat. *famēs*: "Scenario 1" involves a development based directly on the original *m*-stem just described, while "scenario 2" is based on a thematized version of the *m*-stem.

(i) *Scenario 1* (athematic *m*-stem)
Given Ital. **χu-* > pre-Lat. **φu-* (> Lat. *fu-*), the *m*-stem paradigm (with generalized zero grade) would develop in pre-Latin as nom. **φú(u̯)ōm*, obl. **φūm-és*/*-éi*/*-ḗ*, loc. **φu(u̯)ám-i*. But the intolerable allomorphy of such a paradigm would surely have been leveled; and if the original abstract 'gaping' had by this time been concretized, e.g., as '(gaping) cavity, maw' (as assumed for the background of the Germanic and Baltic 'palate, gums, etc.' words), the loc. sg. could have served as a formal pivot (as already mooted above), whence a generalized stem **φu(u̯)ám-*. Only two things remain (both treated further below), first the phonology of **φu(u̯)ám-* > **φu̯am-* > **φam-* (with a "syllabic reduction", which I will claim, in § 7, to be phonologically regular), and secondly (§ 8) the *ē*-inflection and the related matter of the semantics of 'hunger' (for which I will invoke, for this scenario, the instr. sg. **φu(u̯)am-ē̄*).

(ii) *Scenario 2* (thematized *m*-stem)
As often with marginal athematic formations, the original *m*-stem could have been thematized, i.e., *$\hat{g}^{h}$*uh$_2$em-* → *$\hat{g}^{h}$*uh$_2$em-ó-* > pre-Lat. **φu(u̯)am-ó-* (or at a later stage: **φu(u̯)am-* → **φu(u̯)am-ó-*).[18] Semantically, such a thematization would be expected to result in adjectival function, e.g., 'gaping (adj.)'; in this case, the *ē*-basis of *famēs* would rest on adverbial **φu(u̯)am-ḗ* 'gapingly, with gaping', i.e., with the regular Italic **-ē̄* adverbial formant for thematic adjectives (as in O. *amprufid* 'improperly', U. *rehte* = Lat.-Fal. RECTED 'correctly', OLat. FACILVMED 'very easily', etc.). As is well known, there are two competing accounts of the background of this formation, namely (a) a development based on the PIE instrumental in **-eh$_1$* (with ablatival *-d* added secondarily), or (b) a basis in an *e*-grade variant of thematic abl. sg. **-ōd*.[19] A choice between the two is not required for the problem at hand.

7. Both of the scenarios described above depend on two phonological developments in the prehistory of Latin, namely (i) a syllabic reduction (roughly **φu(u̯)am-* > **φu̯am-*), and then (ii) the loss of post-consonantal **-u̯-* (thus **φu̯am-* > **φam-*, hence Lat. *fam-*). The second of these is entirely straightforward: Post-consonantal *u̯*-loss in this context is regular, cf. *$\hat{g}^{h}$*u̯ero-* > Lat. *ferus* 'wild' (Weiss 2020:175). The syllabic reduction can also be described as regular, but this calls for more extended discussion.

There are two possibilities according to which a syllabic reduction **φu(u̯)am-* > **φu̯am-* could be considered phonologically regular, and they differ essentially in terms of chronology. As noted by Peters (1980: 290 n. 243) with regard to an example that has since become widely

18 Formally, compare Li. *žẽmas* 'low' < **d^{h}ǵh-em-ó-*, based on the *m*-stem 'earth' word (*NIL* 88, 95).
19 See, e.g., Weiss 2020: 385, and in somewhat more detail Vine 2017: 766.

cited, there is evidence for a process that he referred to as the “reverse of Lindeman’s Law”, in which an unaccented high vowel (or at least the high back vowel /u/) preceding another vowel, in a hiatus context resulting from laryngeal loss (and probably restricted to sequences longer than two syllables), undergoes glide formation: thus Gk. σάος ‘safe and sound’ < **tu̯áu̯o-*, arising from earlier (trisyllabic) **tu.áu̯o-* (with laryngeal hiatus) < **tuh$_2$-éu̯o-* (belonging with the root **teu̯h$_2$-* ‘swell, become strong’ of Ved. *távīti* etc.; see *LIV* s.v., with n. 1). The reduction of **tu.áu̯o-* to **tu̯áu̯o-* must have occurred at a very early stage, given **tu̯-* > Gk. σ- as a development that can be assigned to Proto-Greek, as well as the early period that must be assigned to the hiatus sequence resulting from laryngeal loss. Since the early discussion of Gk. σάος by Peters, additional examples have been cited, especially by S. Neri for data outside Greek.[20] See, for example, Neri 2019: 58 on **suHeu̯inó-* ‘pig’ > **su.eu̯inó-* (with laryngeal hiatus) > Gmc. **su̯īna-* (OHG *swīn* ‘pig, boar’). Similarly, for the background of Lat. *bonus* ‘good’ (OLat. DVENOS, i.e., /du̯enos/), Neri (2017: 165) operates with a preform **duh$_1$-enó-*,[21] whence **du.eno-* (with laryngeal hiatus) and then **du̯eno-* (by “reverse of Lindeman’s Law”). Even if alternative root etymologies are available (see Neri 2017: 165 n. 290 for discussion), a background in **duH-enó-* (hence susceptible to the same treatment) is likely.[22] Thus the sequence in question (here using, as in §§ 5 and 6 (i), the leveled zero-grade stem in loc. sg. **ĝ^{h}uh$_2$émi* but with instr. sg. desinence **-eh$_1$*) would result in a hiatus sequence **ĝ^{h}u.ámē* after laryngeal loss and coloring. Applying the “reverse of Lindeman’s Law” treatment, this would then yield **g^{h}u̯amē* and pre-Latin **famē.*

There is a second type of process that could in principle be invoked to account for a syllabic reduction **φu(u̯)am-* > **φu̯am-*, but necessarily at a later stage (or stages) than the “reverse of Lindeman’s Law”. As discussed elsewhere (e.g., Vine 2006, 2012), there is evidence that a period of mobile accent, corresponding at least in part to PIE patterns of mobile accent (but probably realized as stress), survived into early Italic and predated the so-called “period of initial stress” that accounts for widespread syncope in Italic (as well as vowel weakening in Latin and, to a lesser degree, in Sabellic).[23] During this early period of Italic mobile accent, non-initial accent could in my view lead to syncope in initial (therefore unaccented) syllables, of the type pre-Lat. **ko-u̯irī-nó-* (with oxytone adjectival accent) > Lat. *Quirīnus* ‘deified Romulus’ or **ko-aís-e/o-* and desiderative **ko-aís-s-e/o-* > Lat. *quaerō* ‘ask’ and *quaesō* ‘seek’.[24] Thus a theoretical Italic instr. sg. **φu(u̯)ám-eh$_1$* or **φu(u̯)am-éh$_1$*, with non-initial accent, could have led to **φu̯amē*, as a result of initial-syllable syncope of this kind. At a still later stage, a similar effect could be triggered by the Classical Latin penultimate accent, as shown (Vine 2016b) for the background of Lat. *bessis* ‘two thirds of an *as*’ < **du̯essis* < **du(u̯)éssis* (at the time of the penultimate accent) < **dúessis* (at the time of initial stress, with vowel weakening and univerbation) < **dú.assis*, i.e., a compressed version (with elision) of an original phrase like *duo* [*partes*]

20 Warm thanks to Sergio Neri for helpful discussion of this phenomenon.

21 The root in question is **deh$_1$u-*/**duh$_1$-* ‘zusammenfügen, ordnen’, as in TA *tsuwā-* ‘sich fügen, passen’, Go. *tewa* ‘Ordnung’; cf. *LIV* s.v. **deu̯h$_2$-*, n. 1 and *LIV Add.* s.v. **deh$_1$u̯-*.

22 For recent discussion of possible connection with Ved. *dúvas-* ‘gift, offering’ and the root **d(e)uH-* ‘(religiös) verehren etc.’ (*IEW* 2. *deu-*, 218–219), and against the popular approach to *dúvas-* involving an alleged enlarged root **deh$_3$u-* (to **deh$_3$-* ‘give’), see Vine 2022: 453–454.

23 On the early Italic accent, see Weiss 2020: 118–119.

24 This background for *Quirīnus* (and similar material, such as *quirīs* ‘fellow-citizen’, *Quirītēs* ‘Roman citizens’): von Planta 1899: 57, Kretschmer 1920, Szemerényi 1959; for *quaerō*/*quaesō*: Szemerényi 1959, Meiser 1998: 193 and 2003: 126, Hackstein 2011: 111, *LIV* s.v. **h$_2$eu̯is-*, nn. 8 and 10, and *LIV Add.* s.v. *h$_2$eu̯is-* ad n. 8.

assis.[25] But unlike the situation with Lat. *bessis*, there is no reason to think that a sequence **φu(u̯)am-* (without having undergone vowel weakening) would have survived the period of initial stress late enough for this version of initial-syllable syncope to have applied.

8. We may conclude with some further comment on the development of *ē*-inflection of Lat. *famēs* and brief consideration of the semantic evolution envisioned in the present proposal.

It should already be clear that the *ē*-inflection of Lat. *famēs* ("solution ingredient (iii)", § 3 above) is here taken to be secondary, much as with *diēs* and *rēs* (§ 2), based on a pivotal form in *-ē* (whether instr. sg. in an athematic paradigm ["scenario 1"] or an instr. adv. in *-ē* ["scenario 2"], § 6); thus (formally) instr. **famē* (> **famēd,* cf. 5th-declension abl. *-ēd*, OLat. DIED etc.), or adv. *-ē*(*d*) (Lat.-Fal. RECTED etc., § 6) → new nom. "*famēs*" (abl. *famē*).[26] Derivationally, this amounts to a so-called "decasuative" formation, a derivational type that has recently come in for some justifiable revisionist critique (Fortson 2020). Nevertheless, Fortson arrives at a conclusion (2020: 94) that "Most 'living' decasuatives … either fit the semantic profile of deadverbials and/or are built to fossilized case-forms and/or to basic vocabulary," features that may apply to the derivational scenarios sketched here for the background of Lat. *famēs.*

In terms of semantics ("solution ingredient [iv]", § 3 above): A more or less "direct" development (**famē*(*d*) → "*famēs*") seems possible, e.g., according to one of the following paths (based on the above morphological proposals):

> (i) instr. **famē*(*d*) *'with gaping (= ravenous) maw' (as in the expressions for 'palate etc.' in Germanic and Baltic) > *'hungrily, with hunger' → nom. "*famēs*" 'hunger' (cf. again the obsolete English expression "have a maw" ~ "with a maw" = "be hungry for something", n. 10 above);
>
> (ii) adv. **famē*(*d*) *'with gaping; gapingly' > *'hungrily, with hunger' → nom. "*famēs*" 'hunger'.

Still, it is worth considering another option, namely a secondary development based on the stem **famēli-* that underlies the rare and morphologically isolated adjective *famēlicus* 'hungry, famished' (Pl. 3×, Ter. 1×).[27] In other words, *famēlicus* is extended from a simpler adjective **famē-li-*, in theory an adjectivization ('ravenous') of the original frozen instrumental or adverb **famē* ('with gaping [maw]' or 'gapingly', cf. above); this could have led to a possible analogy *fidē-li-* 'faithful' : *fidēs* 'faith' :: **famē-li-* 'ravenous' : X, X = "*famēs*" 'hunger'.[28] Note finally that this analogical background would remove the need for a decasuative derivation.[29]

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25 Another instance of this kind is Lat. *quirītāre* 'raise a cry' (Varro+) > Late Lat. **crītāre* > Ital. *gridare*, Fr. *crier* (→ Eng. *cry*); additional examples, as well as typological support from outside Latin, in Vine 2016b.

26 For pivotal *famē*(*d*), it is worth noting the high relative frequency of abl. *famē* in early Latin, as for example in Plautus: 15× abl. (typically in fixed expressions of the type 'die from hunger'), vs. 7× nom., 6× acc., 1× dat.; this pattern, of course, could be secondary and need not be considered directly related to the derivational process in question.

27 After Plautus and Terence, the word is rare and post-Classical only, including a Plautine reminiscence at Juv. 14.146 (cf. Pl. *Cas.* 130).

28 On the morphological parallelism **famē-li-* ~ *fidē-li-*, see Leumann 1977: 337, 350; Fruyt 1986: 166 (with references at 166 n. 52).

29 This is a revised and updated version of material presented at the University of Copenhagen (block seminar "Studies in Latin Etymology and Phonology", 2012), the American Philological Association, now Society for Classical Studies (144th Annual Meeting, 2013), Kyoto University (Indo-European Round Table, 2016), and online at the Oxford Workshop on Indo-European Accentuation (2021). I am deeply grateful to audience members on those occasions for their helpful comments (some of them individually recognized in footnotes above), and I'm sorry not to have been able to benefit from input by Gary Holland, who, in his usual erudite and collegial fashion, would no doubt have caught any number of errors and infelicities. Remaining problems, of course, are entirely my responsibility.

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